Judge by the outbreak of the present war. The first salvo was reported in Shivpuri two weeks ago where Pichore BJP MLA Pritam Lodhi was seen threatening Karera Sub-Divisional Police Officer (SDOP) Ayush Jakhar in a video. With what exactly? That he would get 10,000 supporters to surround the IPS officer's bungalow and "fill it with cow dung".

Lodhi was upset with Jakhar because he summoned his son to the police station in connection with a collision case. The entitled son was accused of driving around in a Thar with blackened windows and no registration plates—just a plaque mentioning his father as the local MLA, and a siren to boot. Five injuries were reported, and Jakhar had given no leeway to the VIP son. The IPS Association condemned the MLA's remarks, and to cool the air, Lodhi was summoned by the CM and state BJP chief for a reprimand.

Takeaways

- **Biggest recent flashpoint: BJP MLA threatens to fill top cop's house "with cow dung" after he booked VIP's son for rash driving**
- **Besides that viral episode in Shivpuri, top officers have clashed with ministers and kin in Alirajpur, Jabalpur**
- **A minister says the CM's top-down style leaves ministers without a sense of power, while officers find their spine**

FIR AGAINST MANTRI KIN

Then, on April 22, a provincial service officer, Priya Kag, the CEO of a block panchayat in Alirajpur district, was threatened by Inder Singh Chouhan, the brother of state minister Nagar Singh Chouhan. An FIR was filed against Inder Singh after he was seen attempting to assault the CEO outside her office. She was accorded police protection, but did not have the heft of a powerful association to stand behind her.

On April 27, IAS officer Arvind Shah, an additional commissioner in the Jabalpur Municipal Corporation, accused state PWD minister Rakesh Singh of having insulted and abused him. The minister was apparently upset after Shah took an employee to task for dereliction of duty. Former state BJP chief Rakesh Singh, who was Jabalpur MP multiple times, had another story: that Shah had made derogatory remarks about the minister. Shah initially got the backing of his clan—the all-powerful IAS Association—but with a political heavyweight in the mix, and perhaps some internal investigations, it chose to back off.

Madhya Pradesh has had a long tradition of the political class and the bureaucrats usually working together, with very few instances of conflict. So, why are ruling party politicians and officials losing their cool so often this time? Some say the politicians are miffed because the bureaucracy does not recognise their genuine and kosher work. Others just blame it on the scorching summer heat. This time, it seems, it is adding to frayed tempers as well. ■

By **Jumana Shah**

IT'S AN IDEA THAT SHOT LIKE LIGHTNING, or within 10.3 seconds, right into the world's imagination of sport in a dramatic moment 90 years ago. That was when Jesse Owens messed up the notion of white racial superiority at the 1936 Berlin Olympics. The search for the DNA of a champion has been on ever since, tinged by racial notions; India made its own foray with the Special Area Games (SAG) scheme in the 1980s, an ethnic talent hunt that gave us the likes of Limba Ram and Mary Kom. Now Gujarat, an SAG laboratory back in the day, has launched its 21st century spinoff: a five-year Sports Genomics Programme (SGP) to sequence the DNA of 10,000 state athletes across 10 disciplines, hunting for genetic markers that separate champions from the rest.

It may be India's most ambitious sports science experiment yet. Led by the Gujarat Biotechnology Research Centre (GBRC), which already leads India's first tribal genome sequencing initiative, the SGP will perform whole-genome sequencing of the state's athletes in endurance and power sports. The resulting Gujarat Athlete Genome Database (G-AGD) will integrate genotype, physiological and performance data to identify genetic risk factors for injuries, isolate sex- and age-related differences and design rehabilitation protocols.

CITIUS, ALTIUS, FORTIUS!

Athletes will be chosen from five endurance and five power sports, in collaboration with the Sports Authority of Gujarat. The idea is to build a database that can help create a pipeline to deliver top athletes. The driving goal: the wish to qualify, a full century after Owens, for the 2036 Olympics. Its test run, the 2030 Commonwealth Games being hosted in Ahmedabad, is also very much on the radar.

India is running against time. Improving our Olympic medal tally in 2028 and 2032 will be essential to the pitch. The SPG, the first such systemic attempt by any Indian state, is seen as a bio-infrastructural tier here.